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1/25th WEEK

ITEM WISE EDITORIAL ... 17th June, 2019



MANEUVERING AMONG US, RUSSIA & CHINA

UPSC CSE – GS II

International Relations



Learning Space



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... DISCUSSION

17th JUNE, 2019

13

A different tent

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation is becoming vital to India's Eurasia policy

Terrorism, regional cooperation and the future of Afghanistan were major themes at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's Heads of State summit in Bishkek. The grouping, led by Russia and China, which includes Afghanistan and the Central Asian states of Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan, induced India and Pakistan in 2007, and has become an important forum for India's Eurasian neighbourhood. In a world riven by geopolitical contestations, SCO membership provides India a vital counter to some of the other groupings it is a part of, balancing out its stated policy of pursuing "multi-alignments". It is a platform, also for alignments on issues such as energy security, connectivity and trade. With India indicating that it sees little use for SAARC, the SCO provides the only multilateral platform for it to deal in close proximity with Pakistan and Afghanistan. While the failure of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Pakistani counterpart Imran Khan to hold substantive talks at the summit was marked, the occasion provided a setting for them to exchange what India called the "usual pleasantries" at the least. Beyond the summit, the two countries are committed to engaging at several other levels, including the SCO Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure. Pakistan leads the effort to coordinate between the SCO and the UN Office on Drugs and Crime. In a paragraph on Afghanistan and the SCO-Afghanistan contact group, the Bishkek declaration stressed on an inclusive peace process led by "Afghans themselves". SCO countries committed to strengthening economic cooperation and supporting the World Trade Organisation structure, while building more people-to-people ties, tourism and cultural bonds within the grouping.

It is significant to see that where the group has failed to find common ground, such as on India's opposition to China's Belt and Road Initiative, the declaration has mentioned only the other countries in a paragraph praising the project. On the sidelines, Mr. Modi held bilateral meetings with Chinese President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin. This month, Mr. Modi will meet U.S. President Donald Trump on the sidelines of the G-20 summit in Osaka. While the current India-U.S. trade impasse and plans for Indo-Pacific military cooperation will take centre-stage there, it is likely that the U.S.'s specific demands on curbing defence deals with Russia, including on the S-400 anti-missile system, and denying access to Chinese telecoms major Huawei for India's 5G network India will also come up. India's strategy of balancing and straddling the competing interests of these emerging blocs will be tested. But the SCO collective and the bilateral meetings in Bishkek are an important indicator early in the Modi government's second tenure of the foreign policy arc it is attempting.

BISHKEK LESSONS

SCO summit underlined that manoeuvring among US, China and Russia is now a permanent condition for Indian diplomacy

ALTHOUGH THE shadow of Pakistan followed him to the Bishkek summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation last week, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had bigger fish to fry at the forum that is constructing a new region, now widely described as Eurasia. The SCO brings together two of the world's great powers — China and Russia — and four central Asian nations — Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan — with India and Pakistan. Launched by China and Russia nearly two decades ago, the SCO has also been billed by some as the "Alliance of the East" and as a continental counter to the US and more broadly, the maritime West. For that very reason, it is seen as a major diplomatic challenge to Delhi that has moved steadily closer to the US in recent years and embraced the Indo-Pacific maritime construct.

India's navigation between the two competing worlds had become even more difficult as the US President Donald Trump ratchets up tensions with both China and Russia. His renewal of American confrontation with Iran and the threat to pull out of Afghanistan have thrown the region into fresh turmoil. Undaunted at Bishkek, Modi appeared to revel in India's emerging possibilities in the new dynamic. The big political mandate at home has raised PM's regional stature that he is happy to flaunt. Even as he demonstrated great personal warmth toward China's Xi Jinping, Modi stood his ground on opposing the Belt and Road Initiative and turning down China's advice to begin talks with Pakistan. With President Vladimir Putin of Russia, Modi sought to expand the strategic partnership with Russia to new areas of defence and energy. Modi, however, joined Xi and Putin in opposing the new threats to global trade from new American unilateralism under Trump. The need to manoeuvre between Moscow, Beijing and Washington is now a permanent condition for Indian diplomacy and will be put to test again at the G-20 summit later this month.

On the regional front, PM's bilateral engagement with the host nation Kyrgyzstan underlined the new political commitment to realise the full potential of India's relations with the Central Asian republics. Bishkek summit also revealed India's deepening challenges with Afghanistan and Pakistan. While India continues to emphasise an "Afghan-owned and Afghan-led" peace process, Kabul has become increasingly marginal as major powers negotiate with the Taliban. On a positive note, the forum strongly endorsed India's concerns on cross-border terrorism. Modi did exchange pleasantries with Prime Minister Imran Khan, but is in no mood to revive talks without major steps from Pakistan on shutting down its terror factories. And, Iran's domestic standing is diminishing by the day as a series of political and economic crises envelop Pakistan. Modi, then, is willing to wait.

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.

DRAFT QUESTION

"The success of Indian diplomacy in future hinges on maneuvering among U.S., China and Russia". Discuss.

13 A different tent

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Terrorism, regional cooperation and the future of Afghanistan were major themes at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's Heads of State summit in Bishkek. The grouping, led by Russia and China, which includes Afghanistan and the Central Asian states of Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan, inducted India and Pakistan in 2017, and has become an important forum for India's Eurasian neighbourhood. In a world riven by geopolitical contestations, SCO membership provides India a vital counter to some of the other groupings it is a part of, balancing out its stated policy of pursuing "multi-alignments". It is a platform also for alignments on issues such as energy security, connectivity and trade. With India indicating that it sees little use for SAARC, the SCO provides the only multilateral platform for it to deal in close proximity with Pakistan and Afghanistan. While the failure of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Pakistani counterpart Imran Khan to hold substantive talks at the summit was marked, the occasion provided a setting for them to exchange what India called the "usual pleasantries" at the least. Beyond the summit, the two countries are committed to engaging at several other levels, including the SCO Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure. Pakistan leads the effort to coordinate between the SCO and the UN Office on Drugs and Crime. In a paragraph on Afghanistan and the SCO-Afghanistan contact group, the Bishkek declaration stressed on an inclusive peace process led by "Afghans themselves". SCO countries committed to strengthening economic cooperation and supporting the World Trade Organisation structure, while building more people-to-people ties, tourism and cultural bonds within the grouping.



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13 Bishkek lessons

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SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION SUMMIT IN BISHKEK

POINT NO.1 ... CLEAR MESSAGE TO INDIAN FOREIGN POLICY

1 SCO is termed as the “Alliance of the East” and considered as continental counter to the U.S. and more broadly, the maritime West.



2 Now, it becomes challenging for India which moved closer to the U.S. in recent years and embraced the Indo-Pacific maritime construct.



SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION SUMMIT IN BISHKEK

POINT NO.2

... AMID TRADE TENSIONS & CONFRONTATIONS



- 1 America's confrontation with Iran and threat to pull out of Afghanistan have thrown the region into turmoil.
- 2 Trade tensions and the impending technology war between USA and China made the things more complex.
- 3 USA–Russia relations are also on the downward spiral.

SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION SUMMIT IN BISHKEK

POINT NO.3

... CHALLENGES ON AFGHANISTAN FRONT



- 1 There are several challenges with Afghanistan and Pakistan, cross-border terror emanating from Pakistan is the continuous challenge.
- 2 India emphasizes on Afghan-owned and Afghan-led peace process.
- 3 But, Afghanistan Government is becoming increasingly marginal as major powers negotiate with Taliban.

SCO SUMMIT ... PRAGMATIC APPROACH BY INDIA

7 The Prime Minister exchanged pleasantries with Pakistan PM Imran Khan, but declined to revive talks, without major steps from Pakistan for shutting down its terror facilities.

6 PM's bilateral engagement with Kyrgyzstan underlines the new political commitments in the region.

5 The Prime Minister also joined China and Russia in opposing the new threats to Global Trade from New American Unilateralism.



1 Shri Narendra Modi is more confident after the massive victory in 17th Lok Sabha.

2 He is clear about opposing "Belt and Road Initiative".

3 The PM turned down China's advice to begin talks with Pakistan.

4 The Prime Minister is for the expansion of the Strategic Partnership with Russia to new areas of Defence and Energy.



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